

The Nicest No

The principle. Tobi has never once said no to an invitation. He asks Code Overlord for a way out of a stag do, and its agents build him an app that declines for him, kindly, with a card in the post. It works, so he has Code Overlord turn it into a product anybody can use, program a robot arm he orders from China to write every card by hand, and wire it to couriers so every no arrives with a present. It catches on until nobody goes to anything any more.

Why it is funny. Every no arrives with something lovelier than the person would have been, so the more people stay away, the happier everybody gets. Nobody in it finds this odd, least of all the man who built it.

In February a man called Lee, who Tobi has never met, added him to a stag do in Riga, and Tobi said yes.

"I can't say no to people." A pause. "It ain't the word. It's their face."

So he typed one sentence into Code Overlord.

"Read my diary every evening and get me out of all of it. Be kind about it."

By four its agents had built him The Nicest No: a schedule called Tomorrow that runs at six every evening, and a card in the post with thenicestno.com along the bottom.

"How long did that take you?"

"Me?" A beat. "I put the kettle on."

Lee replied inside the hour, *no worries mate, proper gent*, with a photo of the shirts: the groom's face on the front, RIGA 2028 on the back.

"It worked. First time in my life." A pause. "So I had Code Overlord make it for everybody."

Sign up, connect your diary, four pound a month. A book club in Dulwich now meets by not meeting. There is a screen called Exceptions, for things you want to go to. Nobody fills it in.

"Anyone can get a printed card, innit. So I ordered a robot arm from China."

It came in a crate, with the manual in Mandarin.

"Did you read the manual?"

"Code Overlord read the manual."

By teatime its agents had it writing in his handwriting, in real biro. His mum, in her hall, beside a framed card.

"He couldn't come to my seventieth."

"Is that his handwriting?"

"No." She keeps looking at it. "It's better."

By June there are forty arms in a railway arch off Rye Lane, writing all night.

"Then I had Code Overlord send a present with every one."

It buys the present, a courier brings it, and you score everyone out of ten.

"What does a two get?"

"A beautiful card."

"And a ten?"

"A beautiful card." A beat. "And a pizza oven."

So people started inviting each other to things on purpose. Ade has had a barbecue every Saturday since July.

"Do you go?"

"He'd be gutted."

"Has he got a barbecue?"

"Four. People sent them."

By September nobody in Britain goes to anything, and everybody is delighted. Femi's wedding: the order of service lists them under Apologies, and the first name on it is the groom's.

"It was in his diary." A pause. "He never put it in Exceptions."

The bride is on her own at the front, a present on every chair.

"How was your wedding?"

"Best day of my life."

"Was he there?"

"No." She holds up a honeymoon for one. "He was a ten."

On screen: PECKHAM, 2034.

Nobody has been to anything for six years. Nobody has ever been happier. A seven-year-old in a paper crown, in a front room full to the ceiling with parcels.

"Who came to your party?"

"Nobody." A beat. "Best one ever."

The arch still writes all night. Tobi is on his sofa, doing nothing.

"What do you do all day?"

"Nothing." A pause. "It's lovely."

"Would you recommend Code Overlord?"

"I typed one sentence into it, and by four it had built The Nicest No. I'd love to come round and show you." A pause. "You'll get a card." A beat. "You're a two."

Brand card. Nothing after it.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One plain sentence typed at a kitchen table, and windows opening underneath it until one is handing work out to the others. A schedule called Tomorrow with its cadence in plain English and its instruction showing. Each new ask going back into the same workshop: sign-ups and a subscription, the driver for an arm whose manual only an agent could read, shops and couriers, a budget out of ten. The laptop shut while forty biros keep writing in the arch.

The spine. Tobi could not say no to a stag do, so he had Code Overlord build The Nicest No to say it for him, kindly. It worked, so he had it made into a product anybody can use, with a robot arm from China writing every card by hand and a courier bringing a present with every one, until nobody in Britain goes to anything, everybody is happier than they have ever been, and he does nothing at all. The reversal a listener can repeat: nobody turns up to anything any more, and everybody loves it.

How this was made. Rebuilt on 19 September 2026 to the client's note on the previous two-minute cut: the robot arm from China as a proper rung, the product anybody can use, nobody turning up and everybody delighted, and a jump to 2034 with Tobi content and doing nothing. The general election is gone. Condensed from the rebuilt long version, `2026-09-19-film-the-nicest-no-long.md`, which also keeps the christening, the cloned-voice phone call, the flower stall, the courier at two hundred weddings and Christmas at his mum's. The gags kept here come from the comedians' panel (Julia Davis, Chris Morris, Tim Robinson, Jimmy Carr, Peter Kay, two rounds). This cut has not been re-rated. Essence check, 19 September 2026: cut Lee alone in Riga in all fourteen shirts (the one beat where a no leaves someone worse off, against an essence where everyone is happier) and the man in the dressing gown (a second version of the 2034 beat, and a second date).

Production note. Accent: the whole cast is South London, Peckham and Camberwell, his mum, Ade, Lee, the bride and the boy in the paper crown alike. It lives in the grammar and never in the spelling ("It ain't the word", "four pound a month", "innit"). The interviewer is the house voice, off camera. Dates: RIGA 2028 on the back of the stag shirts, once, for the main story, February to September 2028; then one caption, PECKHAM, 2034, for the flash-forward. The robot arm is real kit: a desktop arm off a Chinese website with a pen in its gripper, driven by code Code Overlord's agents wrote; the card printer, the shops and the bicycle couriers are all services one person could sign up to in 2026. Structure: the Snowball, with a flash-forward. Ending family: absurd success, played as contentment.

Three things to decide. First, the robot arm is also in You Only Pick Your Mates (an arm writing letters in a unit in Luton). He asked for it here by name, so recommend keeping it here and making that film's arm a printer. Second, the ten's present: a pizza oven, because the hot tub and the jet ski are already used in Nina and Ask Bev; recommend keeping it. Third, Riga: Lee alone at the bar in all fourteen shirts was cut in the essence check, because it is the one beat where a no leaves someone worse off and the essence is that everyone is happier. The opening still pays off on his reply, "proper gent". Recommend leaving it out.